

PIYAL BHATTACHARJEE



The Jail House Rock

DELHI When Congress MP Sachin Pilot courted arrest in Jaipur on October 2, little did he realise that he would be thrown into a damp cell for three days and treated almost like a hardened criminal. "Gujjars were being branded as violent so we decided to lead a peaceful demonstration on Gandhi Jayanti," he says.

However Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje decided to send out a message of her own. While almost a lakh of the other protestors

were also arrested, they were kept in temporary jails and allowed visitors. Pilot was the only one taken to Jaipur's Central Jail and locked up in Barrack No. 1 where he was kept in an isolated cell, made to sleep on the floor and not allowed to meet anyone, not even his legal counsel. BJP MP G.L. Bhargava was also not allowed to meet him.

An angry Pilot now wants to showcase this as an example of the vindictiveness of the Raje Government. In a letter to

HITTING BACK: Pilot the National Human Rights Commission, he has asked for an enquiry against the violation of his fundamental rights. He says, "This was illegal detention with malicious intent. You cannot crush opposition with brute force." Unlike other criminals, it was well after 24 hours when he was presented before a magistrate on October 4, after which he was given a police escort and put on an airplane bound for Delhi. He now plans to file a case against the chief minister.

Pilot was arrested under Section 151 of CrPC. This charge is usually levied in riot cases as a "preventive arrest" if the police feel that a person has "designs to commit any offence" and "that the offence cannot be otherwise prevented". The irony is that it was the young MP who had insisted that the demonstration be a peaceful one. As this Pilot has discovered, in today's rocky political terrain, not every landing is smooth.

by Priya Sahgal

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Babasaheb Bhosale, 86, former chief minister of Maharashtra. He began his legislative career after being elected in 1980 to the state assembly from Nehru Nagar in suburban Kurla.

DIED: Laxmi Mall Singhvi, 76, jurist, statesman, former BJP member of the Rajya Sabha and India's longest serving High Commissioner to the United Kingdom.



STEPPED DOWN: Bakul Dholakia as director of Indian Institute of Management-Ahmedabad, following the completion of his five-year tenure. He beat all other B-schools to reach a foreign shore first despite opposition from HRD ministry.

TESTED: Training trial of Agni, India's short-range nuclear capable army variant of the ballistic missile with a range of 700 km. This will lead to its full operationalisation.

VIS-A-VIS H.D. DEVE GOWDA Janata Dal (Secular) chief **versus** YASHWANT SINHA Bharatiya Janata Party leader

The BJP tried to make Karnataka a Hindutva laboratory like Gujarat. The ball is now in their court. Let them resolve the confusion.



SAURABH SINGH

Gowda's remarks are ridiculous. The JD(S) is seeking to justify its betrayal and dishonesty by not adhering to the power sharing deal.

EPILOGUE: People should take a lesson from this blame game—keep the power hungry out of power.